with multiple accounts amplifying them. Manipur Police have also filed a case with the cybercrime division.

For Biren Singh, who has held on to his office despite mounting pressure and calls for resignation, high stakes are attached to the Supreme Court probe. If the court validates the tapes' authenticity, they could lend weight to accusations that Singh's government was actively complicit in the violence. His political survival would be in grave jeopardy, potentially unravelling his administration's legitimacy and leading to wider political and legal scrutiny of his role in the violence. The tapes could also prove damaging to the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), which has supported Singh throughout the crisis. A backlash could potentially reshape the party's standing in the Northeast, where communal stability has often been a fragile accomplishment. However, if the tapes are found to be doctored, as the government asserts, it would validate the administration's stance that a concerted campaign of misinformation has been directed at destabilising Manipur and undermining Singh's reputation in what are already fraught times.

Yet beyond the political ramifications, the Supreme Court's decision to examine the recordings underscores its role as a guardian of constitutional rights, willing to step in when state mechanisms are alleged to be compromised. The court's ruling on the authenticity of these tapes will likely set a precedent in matters of alleged state complicity in communal violence, signalling whether India's judiciary can hold powerful officials accountable amid a climate of political and social unrest. For Manipur, the ruling could either mark the beginning of a new era of accountability or validate claims of victimisation, depending on where the truth lies. In either case, the court's decision will resonate far beyond Manipur's borders, as communities and leaders across India watch to see if justice will find a voice amid the noise of misinformation and unrest. ■



BIG SHOUT-OUT
Someshwara Swamiji of Makhanapura Gurupeeta (standing) and Union minister Shobha Karandlaje (left) at a protest in Vijayapura, Nov. 5

KARNATAKA

Furore Over Waqf Land

By Ajay Sukumaran

In the heat and dust of the assembly bypolls that concluded on November 13 in Karnataka, the state's Congress government found itself grappling with a thorny issue that has snowballed into a controversy with nationwide ramifications. Hence it came to be that, amid the shrill election campaigns for the Channapatna, Shiggaon and Sandur assembly seats, the event that garnered national attention was the November 7 visit to Karnataka by a parliamentarian from Uttar Pradesh, Jagdambika Pal. Famous as the "one-day chief minister of UP", the BJP's Domariyaganj MP chairs the 21-member joint parliamentary committee (JPC) examining the contentious Waqf (Amendment) Bill, 2024, introduced in the Lok Sabha this August.

Pal's visit to Vijayapura district came two weeks after the BJP MP from Bengaluru, Tejasvi Surya, also a member of the JPC, alleged that farmland running into thousands of acres in the northern district was being claimed as Waqf property. He accused the Siddaramaiah-led government of abetting this by serving notices to farmers and effecting mutations in land records—by inserting a Waqf claim that will essentially preclude any land transaction—without "due process of law".

Waqf refers to the charitable dedication of a property to Allah, and comprises mosques, dargahs, idgahs, kabristans, orphanages and hostels among others. On October 25, Surya said he had met farmers from Honavad village in Vijayapura where about 1,200 acres of farmland was alleged to have been claimed as Waqf property. Following this accusation, Karnataka BJP leaders held protests, alleging appeasement and set up a fact-finding committee to inquire into what they readily termed